

"Do things that don't scale" is the most famous rule in Silicon Valley startup history (created by Paul Graham, the founder of Y Combinator, who funded Airbnb, Stripe, and DoorDash).

Here is what it means, why beginners get it wrong, and exactly how you do it for your app:

1. The Rookie Founder Mistake vs. The Senior Founder Secret

The Rookie Mistake: "I will write the code, put the app on the Play Store, sit back, and wait for thousands of people to use it automatically without me doing any manual work." →→ This app always dies.

The Senior Founder Secret: "Software cannot create human magic on Day 1. For my first 50 users, I will manually do everything by hand—like a luxury 5-star hotel concierge—to make sure their first experience is 100% unforgettable."

2. Famous Examples of "Things That Don't Scale"

Airbnb: When Airbnb started, nobody was booking. The founders (Brian and Joe) literally flew to New York, knocked on hosts' doors, took professional photos of apartments with their own cameras, and paid the hosts' rent. You can't do that for 1 million houses, but doing it for the first 30 houses built Airbnb.

DoorDash: The founders didn't hire delivery drivers. For the first 6 months, the founders drove their own cars and delivered food to customers themselves to learn every single friction point.

3. What You Will Do Manually for Your First 20 Meetups (Step-by-Step)

Let's say a plan with 4 people (Priya, Rahul, Ananya, and Vikram) unlocks for Saturday 5:00 PM at Third Wave Coffee, Koramangala.

Here is the manual "White-Glove" magic you do behind the scenes:

🕒 Step A: 2 Hours Before the Meetup (Remove All Anxiety)

What you do:

You call the cafe: "Hey, reserving a 4-seater table for 5:00 PM under the name 'SquadIn'."

You send a quick note inside the app chat:

"Hey crew! Table #4 is reserved under 'SquadIn' at Third Wave. When you walk in, just tell the barista you're with the SquadIn crew. Have a great time!"

Why it matters: Meeting strangers makes people nervous. They worry: "What if I reach the cafe and look lost? What if there are no seats?" You completely removed that fear with a 30-second phone call.

👤 Step B: During the Meetup (The "Surprise & Delight" Moment)

What you do:

You send a quick UPI payment (₹150–₹200) to the cafe barista or pay for a plate of fries / cold brew for their table.

The waiter walks up to their table and says: "Hey, this plate of fries is on the house from the SquadIn team!"

The Psychological Effect:

The 4 strangers will look at each other and say: "Whoa, this app is incredible!"

They will pull out their phones, take a photo of the fries and coffee, and post an Instagram Story tagging your app for free.

📞 Step C: 1 Hour After the Meetup (Personal Founder Care)

What you do:

You send a personal WhatsApp message to Priya:

"Hey Priya! Hope you had a fun time with Rahul and the crew today. Did everyone treat you with respect? Anything we can improve for your next weekend plan?"

The User's Reaction:

Priya feels: "Wow, the founder actually cares about my safety. This isn't some sketchy anonymous app—this is a real community."

Priya now tells her 5 female roommates in her PG to download the app.

4. Why This Makes Your App BOOM

You only need to do this manually for the first 50 to 100 users:

50 Users have an unforgettable 10/10 manual experience



Each user tells 3–4 roommates, coworkers & friends



You get 200–400 new verified users for ₹0 in ad spend



The network density explodes in that neighbourhood!

Once you do this manually 20 times, you will understand every single detail of how Indian strangers interact at cafes. Then, you can turn those manual lessons into automated software features for the next 10,000 users!